

AT A RUNNING TIME OF TWO MINUTES AND 54 SECONDS, MEMU AAGAMU IS A RAGE ON COKE STUDIO INDIA'S YOUTUBE CHANNEL. WITH OVER 75 MILLION VIEWS, THE SONG, NAY MUSIC VIDEO, NAY TV COMMERCIAL...

...OKAY, ALL THREE put together, has lyrics in Hindi, Telugu and, believe it or not, in Korean. It stars Telugu films' superstar Allu Arjun (think *Pushpa*), Bollywood singer Armaan Malik, and South Korean girl band TRI.BE.

Right. So, foot-tapping music, pleasing optics, cool fusion... all very well, but what's the point? The point, folks, is Coke Studio; those familiar with the popular music television series would be wondering what happened. After all, Coke Studio is ordinarily meant to promote new singing talent—supported by star singers—from multiple influences ranging from classical Indian to rock and pop music. None of the protagonists in *Memu Aagamu* fits into this description. Armaan Malik is neither a new singer nor in the league of superstars. The Korean girls, extremely talented, are not in the Indian music scene. And Allu Arjun, for all his popularity, is an actor lip-syncing to Malik's crooning, not a singer.

So, again, what's the point? The larger point here is that this video exemplifies Coca-Cola India's new, counter-intuitive approach towards marketing—be it in the media mix, launching new brands, approach to digital, or looking to make product offerings relevant through the year. How about a bottle of Sprite in winter? Fancy a Coca-Cola with your lunch? Or a Maaza after dinner? You get the drift.

Now, get this, too. This disruptive strategy is a new one, rolled out in mid-2022, so its impact is yet unknown. It is an appendage, newly attached to an already strong, conventional gravy train. Across concentrates and bottling, the Indian arm of the global beverage major is an over ₹20,000-crore business (Coca-Cola India's total income is ₹3,192 crore in FY22, the balance is from bottlers; see chart *'The Clink*

of Bottlers'). Growth from the conventional strategy—stable brands, lots of advertising, celebrity endorsements, and sponsoring high-profile sporting events—is far from challenged. The outcome of the conservative approach: Thums Up and Sprite are today \$1-billion brands in terms of retail sales. And Maaza, with \$500 million in the bag, and growing, is on the way. (Interestingly, mother brand Coke is at No. 4 in the in-house pecking order, behind Maaza, and is followed by Limca.)

So, why experiment? Fact is, the opportunity and potential the folks in India see outweigh the conservative approach. They feel there is still an India that has not had a taste of the company's offerings. And the size of that market is enticing. Arnab Roy, Coca-Cola India & Southwest Asia's Vice President and Head of Marketing, points to the opportunity: "Per capita consumption for our categories is still very low in India and that offers a huge growth opportunity." In 2021, the per capita consumption of soft drinks in India was at 20 litres, according to data platform Statista; the figure was over 130 litres for the US.

The other reason for the experimental strategy is a practical one. Coca-Cola's core brands are all 'cold drinks', which go cold (pun intended) in winter months. This also means that for at least four months every year, Coca-Cola's distribution infrastructure is dismantled. And then rebuilt the following year. That is a painful and expensive exercise. Its bitter rival PepsiCo, at ₹6,180 crore in revenues, has the advantage of having a substantial foods business, which it can rely on in winter months (in FY22, 88 per cent of its revenues came from food). Coca-Cola has no such buffer.

Ergo, the two-fold plan: let's do the done thing; and let's try some risky, too.

At the helm of this divergent strategy is Sanket Ray, 49, President of Coca-Cola India & Southwest Asia. With